

THE CLOCKWORK STAR

Mira reached the ruined observatory before sunrise. She had come because her brother Arun vanished there three nights earlier, leaving only a note that mentioned a clockwork star beneath the western dome. The townspeople feared the hill and would not follow her.

At the broken gate, Mira met Tomas, a young mapmaker carrying a silver compass. The needle did not point north. It turned toward the observatory and trembled whenever the wind crossed the empty windows. Tomas said Arun had borrowed one of his maps and marked a chamber that did not exist on any official plan.

Inside, they found a brass bell hanging above a staircase. When the bell rang by itself, the staircase rotated and revealed a hidden room. Arun was alive inside the chamber, trapped beside a machine shaped like a star. He explained that the machine copied the night sky and could predict storms, but its gears had locked around his coat.

Mira stopped the machine by removing the smallest blue gear. Tomas freed Arun, and the false stars above them faded. They returned to town carrying the blue gear, the silver compass, and Arun's unfinished map.